HOT-SMOKED SALMON

makes about 1¾ cups

During salmon season in Yurok country, it's all hands on deck. The salmon run fast and furious, and an important food source for the whole year must be harvested and processed in a few short weeks.

The Yurok people smoke salmon much like people do farther north, either by staking it alongside an open fire or using a smoke box. To preserve salmon for longer keeping, they'll take some of that smoked salmon and can it.

This recipe is for salmon strips that are rich in smoke flavor, well seasoned, and flaky. I make sure to smoke it to at least 145°F, because wild fish can contain parasites that are killed off by cooking (or freezing).

To preserve the salmon in jars, it's crucial to follow safe canning practices and make sure the jars are fully sealed before storing.

The cure for this smoked salmon is simply salt, but if you'd like to make it sweeter, you can add equal parts maple sugar.

1 (2-pound) skin-on salmon fillet

½ cup coarse sea salt

Sunflower oil, for the grates

Cut the salmon lengthwise into 1-inch-wide strips. Then cut the strips so they're about 4 inches long.

Arrange the strips on a baking sheet and season all over with the salt. Refrigerate uncovered for 1 hour.

Rinse the fish then pat dry. Arrange on a rack, skin-side down, and let it stand at a cool room temperature near an open window for 2 hours, or refrigerate uncovered for up to 12 hours. Drying the fish will help the smoke penetrate more.

To use an outdoor smoker: Preheat a smoker to 175°F, according to the manufacturer's instructions.

Oil the grates and set the salmon on top. Smoke to 145°F for about 2 hours if you want some moisture in the fish or continue smoking for 30 minutes to 1 hour longer until it's dry throughout but still pliable. If you want to jar the salmon, you'll want to smoke it just until the fish reaches 145°F. It will cook further in the pressure canner.

To smoke on a gas grill: Lay 2 sheets of heavy-duty aluminum foil on a work surface. Arrange 2 cups dry (not soaked) wood chips on top. Fold up the chips in the foil to form a packet, then use a pencil or pen to poke holes in the top.

Remove one grate from your grill and arrange the packet directly on the burner. Heat over low heat, aiming to get the grill to about 200°F.

Oil the grates, then arrange the salmon on the opposite side of the grill from the smoking packet (indirect heat). Close the lid and cook for about 1 hour, until the fish reaches 145°F. If you'd like your smoked salmon to be drier, add a new packet of wood chips and continue cooking for about 30 minutes longer, until quite dry throughout but still pliable.

Let cool before enjoying or storing. Refrigerate the salmon in an airtight container for up to 5 days.